

Megasthenes's India

(c. 300 BCE)

India is 'the most easterly part of the inhabited world', wrote the Greek historian Herodotus (c. 484–25 BCE). Only a barren desert lies beyond. The Indians, most numerous of all people, are 'almost as black' as Ethiopians. They live in myriad tribes and speak many languages. India's animals and birds, he wrote, are the largest in the world and its wild trees make 'a kind of wool' that's better than sheep's wool, and from which the Indians make clothes.[1]

To the classical Greeks of the fifth century BCE,, India was above all a land of the weird and the creepy. Herodotus never visited India yet recorded legends without scepticism, such as its gold-digging ants bigger than foxes and faster than all animals on earth; a tribe called Padaei whose elderly or ill members are promptly killed, cooked and eaten by their closest friends; tribes that eat raw fish and tribes that eat only wild vegetables; further, all these tribes have sex in the open like herd animals and their men naturally produce black semen.

The reality was much less fantastical. In the preceding millennium, Indo-Aryan culture had evolved with strong Harappan influences. This culture became dominant in the north and found a home in several political units known as *janapada*s. Their literate elites spoke Sanskrit while the rest spoke one of the many Prakrits derived from Sanskrit.[2] By the sixth and